

Laying eggs in water

Fish fertilize their eggs externally, so the females lay unfertilized eggs directly into the water. Instead of having hard shells, fish eggs are usually coated in a soft jelly that will cushion and protect the developing embryos. Most fish do not wait around to see the embryos develop, but simply scatter lots of floating eggs and swimming sperm and leave the outcome to chance. However, some species, such as clown fish, carefully tend to their developing babies.



1 Laying and fertilization
A female clown fish lays her eggs onto a hard surface. The male then releases his sperm to fertilize them.



2 Caring for the eggs
During the week it takes for them to hatch, the father guards the eggs, using his mouth to clean them.



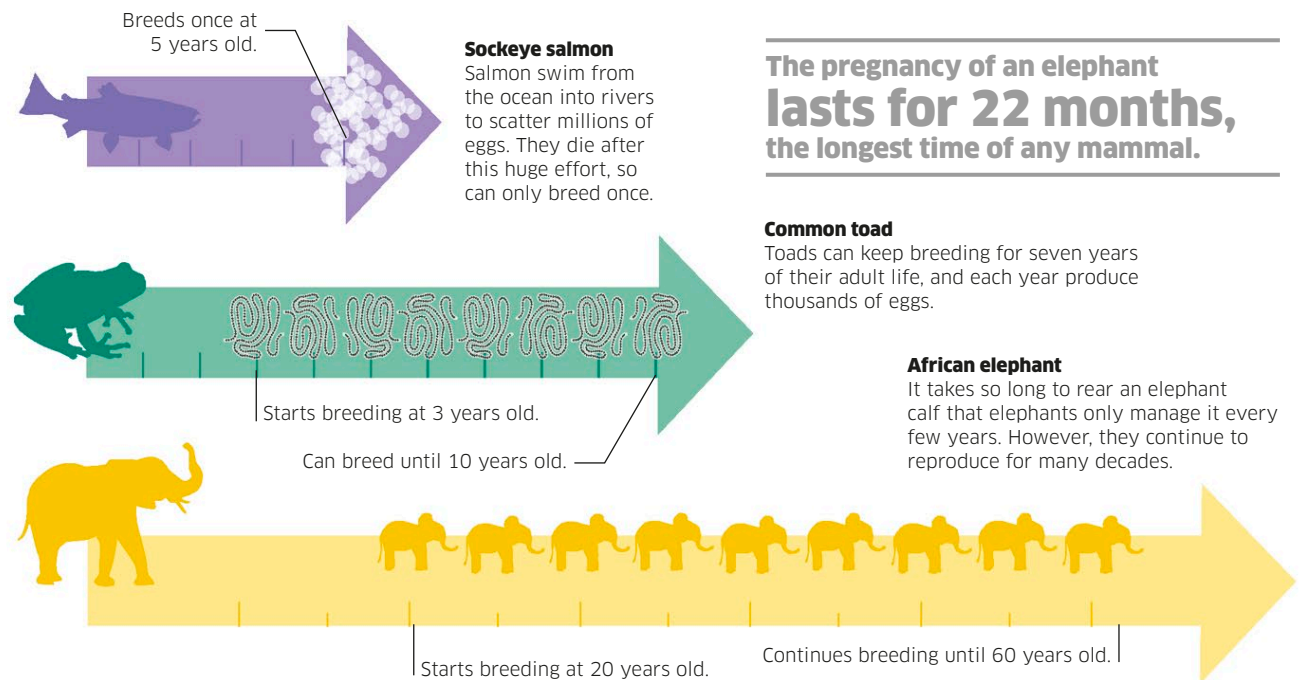
3 Hatching
Tiny babies, called fry, break out of the eggs. They grow quickly, feeding on nutrients in their yolk sac.

Investing in babies

All animals spend a lot of time and effort in breeding, but they invest this energy in different ways. Some—such as many insects and most fish—produce thousands of eggs at once, and a few even die after breeding. Others produce just one baby at a time, but spend a lot of time caring for each one.

Breeding lifetimes

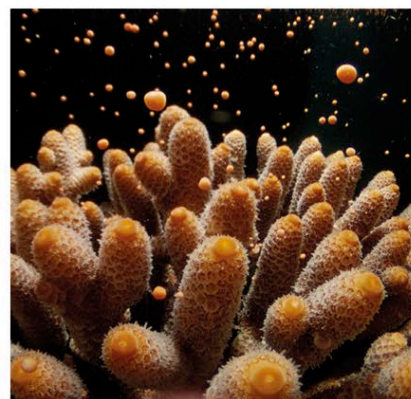
Animals must have fully grown reproductive systems before they can breed, and some can take years to develop these. While some animals breed often throughout their long lives, shorter-lived species make up for their limited life spans by producing many babies each time.



Parental care

The best way to ensure that babies survive is to give them good care when they are at their most vulnerable, but animal parents vary a lot in their degree of devotion. Many invertebrates give limited parental care or none at all. But mammal babies may be nurtured by their parents for many years.

Newborn kangaroos live in a pouch in their mother's bodies, where they continue to grow and develop.



Coral
Adult coral provide no parental care. Young microscopic stages of coral—called larvae—must fend for themselves in the open ocean, where most will get eaten by predators.



Black lace weaver spider
This spider mother makes the ultimate sacrifice for her babies. After laying more eggs for her young to eat, she encourages them to bite her. This stirs their predatory instincts, and they eat her.



Orangutan
Childhood for this tree-living ape lasts well into the teenage years—just like in humans. During this time, the young will stick close to their mother for protection and learn vital survival skills from her.